

Chapter 120-1

Upon hearing this name, a sharp light flashed through Chen Mian's eyes that had been like a pool of stagnant water.

Even her body, which had been sitting loosely, straightened up in an instant.

But a moment later, she returned to how she looked when she first came in.

Even colder than before.

A guarded posture, indifferent gaze, maintaining silence.

The server brought over warm water and asked what coffee she would like.

Chen Mian declined. "No need, thank you."

Her voice was very magnetic, carrying a natural husky quality. When she spoke, it made people feel like she was up in the clouds.

No one could enter her world.

Even the server couldn't help but glance at her a few more times when leaving, especially at her eyes.

Chen Mian continued looking at Liang Shi in silence. After a moment, Liang Shi spoke first: "Don't you have anything you want to say?"

Chen Mian said coldly: "No."

She picked up the glass of warm water beside her, lowered her eyes and took a small sip. The moisture on her lips added a touch of pink to those pale lips.

Outside the huge floor-to-ceiling glass windows were pedestrians coming and going, their footsteps hurried, passing by in twos and threes.

Chen Mian's gaze drifted toward the window, as if unwilling to discuss it further.

But Liang Shi knew that she definitely still wanted to hear something—otherwise, she would have gotten up and left already.

After a moment of thought, Liang Shi handed over a piece of paper.

It was Qi Jiao's diary—the pure Morse code version. This page contained content related to Chen Mian.

It should have been very complex content. An ordinary person seeing it wouldn't think it was Morse code.

But when Chen Mian saw it, she picked it up and scanned it without finding it obscure at all.

A few seconds later, Chen Mian's hand holding the paper was trembling. Her throat moved slightly, and when she spoke again, her voice had become hoarse, choked with emotion: "Where did you get this?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, not rushing to answer, instead letting the atmosphere sink down.

In this strange silence, Chen Mian's gaze was like an unsheathed sword, wishing she would answer immediately, yet still patiently waiting.

Liang Shi took a sip of coffee. The sound of the coffee cup and saucer clinking together rang out. "The phone calls you can still make, the voice you can still hear, the person you can still see—have you never thought about it? Or do you already know everything?"

These words sounded like a riddle, without any logic to speak of.

But Chen Mian understood.

Clearly it was noisy and clamorous outside, and there was still music playing in the café.

But between the two of them, it became quiet. Neither could hear the sounds from outside.

Chapter 120-2

A long time passed—so long that Liang Shi's thoughts had begun to drift, staring blankly at a fixed point—before Chen Mian finally spoke, her voice obscure: "She is not her."

—She is not her.

The phone calls that could still be made—the person answering was not Qi Jiao.

The voice that could still be heard—that was also not Qi Jiao.

The similar face that could still be seen—that still was not Qi Jiao.

Chen Mian's voice seemed to come from the depths of the sea, carrying bone-piercing coldness and deep despair.

Hearing this, Liang Shi met her gaze. Those eyes hidden behind coldness became warm, the corners tinged with a trace of red.

After a moment, Chen Mian asked bluntly: "What do you want to ask?"

"How do you know the person now isn't her?" Liang Shi asked in a low voice.

Chen Mian licked her lips, slowly exhaled, and asked back very softly: "How could I not tell?"

"Have you ever loved someone?" Chen Mian continued to ask.

Liang Shi paused.

"She's dead." Chen Mian said. "No matter how similar that person is, she's just a substitute."

"It's easy to imitate the form, but hard to imitate the spirit. She is her—no one can imitate her." Chen Mian's voice was unusually certain, though one could faintly hear a trace of sorrow.

An artist's words were always somewhat obscure, requiring deeper excavation.

Liang Shi stared at her. "Do you know her true cause of death?"

"I don't know." Chen Mian said. "It should be related to her mother? I'm not sure."

Chen Mian shrugged. "You came to find me—I thought you knew."

Her mood sank again. Without her guard up, her surface indifference looked more like world-weariness.

A heavy sense of world-weariness was revealed through her eyes, through her every movement—exceptionally obvious.

Under that ink-blue hair was her concealed gland. Behind her ear at the gland location was a lily flower tattoo.

She subconsciously rubbed that tattoo, looking at Liang Shi with an indifferent smile. "I'm not anyone to her, so I can't do anything about it."

The implication being—I have no standing to investigate her cause of death, no standing to do anything.

Liang Shi asked again: "Then do you know why she jumped off the building?"

Chen Mian shook her head: "We never saw each other again after she jumped."

Chen Mian didn't know much. She knew very little about Qi Jiao's death.

It was Liang Shi who tactfully told her that her suspicions were correct.

Upon hearing this answer, Chen Mian's expression shifted slightly, seemingly mocking.

When Liang Shi asked her whether it was because of Qi Jiao that she had spoken to her in middle school, Chen Mian nodded.

Chen Mian said that back then, Qi Jiao often mentioned a little sister to her.

She also said she had once seen Qi Jiao watching her figure from the shadows.

Later, when they became close, Qi Jiao told Chen Mian: "She's my little sister."

When mentioning Liang Shi, Qi Jiao would rarely speak at length, her brows and eyes curving into a smile, saying how wonderful it was that she was doing well.

So Chen Mian would talk to her in the art studio, would readily agree to meet her after seeing her messages.

Would agree to requests that were somewhat unreasonable for Chen Mian.

To Chen Mian, Liang Shi was Qi Jiao's "keepsake."

"Did you ever try to stop her?" Liang Shi asked.

Hearing this, Chen Mian curved her lips into a mocking smile. "I told her we should live for each other."

Liang Shi: "...Then she..."

"She probably couldn't hold on anymore." Chen Mian gripped the warm glass, the water inside swaying. The veins on the back of her hand bulged. "She was already in so much pain—how could I selfishly ask her to live for me?"

Chapter 120-3

//

After Chen Mian left the café, Liang Shi sat there alone for a long time.

For the first time ever, Chen Mian left Liang Shi a signature and a drawing.

Using her painter's hands.

Chen Mian's retreating figure was desolate, yet she said to her: "Can you make that person pay?"

Liang Shi looked at her with burning eyes.

Chen Mian said: "Bad people should have to pay a price, right?"

"I can give everything," Chen Mian said. "I'm willing to help her."

—Help her escape.

—And also help Qi Jiao get an answer.

Chen Mian said: "Having come to this world once, she didn't get to see the sun—she should at least get to see the moon."

There should be at least some light.

Only at that moment did Liang Shi ask: "Is that what the moon in your profile picture means?"

Chen Mian didn't answer directly, only told her to look more carefully.

Liang Shi sat in the café and enlarged Chen Mian's profile picture again and again.

In that round moon, she saw a hazy figure.

Faintly hidden within the moon, as if in deep slumber.

The tip of the moon looked exactly like a simple lily flower.

Chen Mian said Qi Jiao loved lilies the most.

Pure, beautiful, gentle—possessing all the wonderful qualities in this world.

Qi Jiao had said: "My life doesn't need to be like a rose, living proudly and passionately. To be like a lily, swaying with the wind, peaceful and romantic—that would be enough to satisfy me."

Her wish was so small, yet it was like a stone thrown into the sea, disappearing without a trace.

Liang Shi's heart felt as if something was blocking it.

This café wasn't far from Minghui Jewelry. After spacing out in the café for a long while, it was only a little past eleven.

Liang Shi glanced at her phone without any desire to play with it.

She grabbed the car keys from beside the table. The car first headed toward the crew in the suburbs, but at the first fork in the road, Liang Shi made a turn.

Heading toward Minghui Jewelry.

In just ten minutes, the car stopped outside the Minghui Jewelry building.

Counting the days, she and Xu Qingzhu hadn't seen each other for five days.

Although they video-called every day according to their schedules, through a phone screen, everything said lacked flavor.

Liang Shi arrived at the building right at twelve o'clock. She took out her phone, wanting to message Xu Qingzhu.

But she paused before sending, and simply parked the car and went upstairs.

A new flower shop had opened downstairs from their office building. All kinds of flowers looked especially eye-catching against this bleak autumn scenery.

When Liang Shi reached the building entrance, she turned to go to the flower shop and bought a bouquet of purple baby's breath.

The shop owner's hearing wasn't very good—she wore hearing aids—but when she smiled, she had sweet dimples. While wrapping the flowers for Liang Shi, she handed her a blank greeting card and a pen.

Liang Shi sat there thinking for a few seconds, then wrote on the paper:

[Xu Qingzhu's life should be like baby's breath—free, romantic, and eternal. —L]

After writing, Liang Shi tucked the greeting card into the bouquet. Carrying the flowers, she actually felt too embarrassed to go up.

She found a secluded corner and stood there holding the bouquet. It happened to be lunch break, and people coming and going all cast glances her way.

While she was hesitating about messaging Xu Qingzhu, someone even came to chat her up and ask for her contact information.

She politely declined, then lowered her head to message Xu Qingzhu: [Are you on break?]

Xu Qingzhu replied instantly: [Mm.]

Liang Shi: [Come down.]

Liang Shi: [I came to see you.]

Chapter 120-4

//

Not far from the Minghui Jewelry building, Sally and Lin Luoxi were bickering with each other, while Xu Qingzhu stood to the side like a glowing light bulb.¹

She didn't feel uncomfortable though.

After all, since university, she had often been the third wheel for these two.

On the surface, the two were going back and forth at each other, but secretly they were sweet as honey.

A couple who had just gotten back together—their honeymoon phase was even longer than when they first started dating, and even more passionate and intense.

Today Sally felt cooped up, so they came down early.

It was only a few minutes earlier than the regular employees, and Sally said she wanted to go eat at that hard-to-reserve army stew restaurant.²

When they came down, Xu Qingzhu was still reading a document on her phone. She was just reaching the end of the document when she almost bumped into someone while walking—Lin Luoxi pulled her back just in time.

She hurriedly finished reading the document before exiting the work app.

She had just exited and hadn't had time to put down her phone when Lin Luoxi patted her arm. "Hey, isn't that Liang Shi?"

Xu Qingzhu stopped walking and looked up to scan around, but couldn't find the right direction. Lin Luoxi had to forcibly turn her head. "Over there."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu see her.

Liang Shi was wearing a camel-colored coat, her long curly hair draped lazily over her shoulders, holding a bouquet of purple baby's breath in her arms. Someone happened to be chatting her up.

An awkward smile appeared on that gentle face, but she still waved the person off.

Sally said from the side: "Who would've thought? Liang Shi is quite popular."

Lin Luoxi scoffed lightly. "Our Zhuzi isn't bad either, okay?"

Sally immediately said: "I didn't say Blanche was bad."

Lin Luoxi was quite annoyed by her particular fondness for Liang Shi. Dissatisfied with her answer, she jabbed her with her elbow.

Sally, with her blonde hair and blue eyes, should clearly have been a cool and aloof beauty, but in front of Lin Luoxi, she became a pitiful little fool, asking aggrievedly: "Why are you mad again?"

Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes at her. "I'm annoyed looking at you."

Sally: "..."

Xu Qingzhu wasn't listening to their conversation. Her phone vibrated slightly—it was a message from Liang Shi.

If it were just two simple sentences appearing on the screen, those two sentences would have made Xu Qingzhu feel pleasantly surprised.

But paired with that lonely figure, those forlorn eyes.

Something in Xu Qingzhu's heart was touched.

Sally suggested: "Call Liang Shi over, let's eat together."

But Xu Qingzhu put away her phone and walked toward Liang Shi without looking back. "You two go eat."

Sally: "?"

A few seconds later, Sally said dazedly: "Blanche just stood us up?"

"What else?" Lin Luoxi answered expressionlessly. "She's someone nourished by love now."

Sally: "..."

Lin Luoxi didn't even look at her and walked off on her own.

It took Sally a moment to react before she jogged after her. "Wait..."

Meanwhile, Liang Shi had been waiting for Xu Qingzhu to reply and hadn't looked up.

Only when she sensed a focused gaze directed at her did she slowly raise her head, and then her eyes met Xu Qingzhu's.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, her eyes slowly curving.

A smile visibly spread across her face.

Liang Shi stood there and smiled along with her.

Without doing anything, just standing there, she was like a painting—different from all the noisy backgrounds of this world.

Or rather, all those people coming and going were just the backdrop.

Liang Shi could only see her.

Meeting again after several days, neither of them spoke.

It was Liang Shi who stepped forward first, handing her the flowers in her arms.

"Is today a special day?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi thought for a moment and shook her head. "Nothing special."

The conversation started from there.

No awkwardness, no unfamiliarity from days apart—just like when they used to spend every day together.

A strand of Xu Qingzhu's hair was blown astray by the wind. Liang Shi reached out to tuck it behind her ear, her hand landing on her cheek, her fingertip brushing against the edge of her ear as she said gently: "Xu Qingzhu, have you not been eating properly?"

"That's your imagination." Xu Qingzhu lowered her head and took out the greeting card, seeing the blessing written on it.

She asked perceptively: "Did you go see Chen Mian?"

Liang Shi: "..."

The comfort of being with Xu Qingzhu was that even if you said nothing, she understood you.

She just didn't know if it was because Xu Qingzhu was smart, or because she was willing to think about things related to her.

She didn't know if Xu Qingzhu was like this only with her, or with everyone.

-
1. Light bulb (电灯泡): Chinese slang for a third wheel—someone who tags along with a couple and "illuminates" their romantic moments, making them feel watched. ↩
 2. Army stew (部队锅): Also known as "budae-jjigae," a Korean fusion stew that originated after the Korean War, made with ingredients like spam, sausages, ramen noodles, and vegetables in a spicy broth. ↩

Chapter 120-5

Liang Shi smiled helplessly, her hand dropping down. "Nothing escapes you."

Xu Qingzhu tucked the greeting card back into the baby's breath, leaned forward, and hugged Liang Shi with the bouquet between them.

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask about what Liang Shi saw or heard when meeting Chen Mian. She only asked: "Teacher Liang, what do you want to eat for lunch today?"

Just like how she had said—Xu Qingzhu, have you not been eating properly?

The tone was familiar, carrying a touch of gentleness.

Amidst this clamor, the heart that had just been restless and lonely was soothed in an instant.

Liang Shi revealed a smile, her tone indulgent: "I'll eat whatever you eat."

Xu Qingzhu thought for half a second. "Is roast duck okay?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Sure."

The cold sun shone upon the earth, and the late autumn wind blew past at an inopportune time.

Yet it didn't make anyone feel cold.

That roast duck restaurant wasn't far—just around the corner, no need to drive.

Xu Qingzhu held the purple baby's breath in her arms. Along the way, they encountered employees from her company, and she kept a cold expression the entire time.

After walking just a few steps, neither knew who moved closer first, who reached out first.

Liang Shi's fingers hooked onto Xu Qingzhu's fingers.

Fingers intertwined.

Even their retreating figures looked exceptionally beautiful.

This scene fell into Chen Liuying's eyes from not far away, and it was especially glaring.

Chen Liuying had been there for a while.

She hadn't gone out in a long time. Today, on a whim, she went out for a walk and unknowingly wandered to the Minghui Jewelry building.

Since she was already here, she thought she'd find Xu Qingzhu and meet with her.

She simply wanted to come find Xu Qingzhu to chat, though she didn't know what about.

Perhaps all beautiful things have thorns, like roses.

Xu Qingzhu was at the top of the food chain among roses.

No one could have imagined that she would actually keep a recording as evidence back then.

In the past month or so, Chen Liuying had lost her endorsements, lost her drama contracts, lost her girlfriend, and several companies were suing her for breach of contract.

She had been to court three times alone, and was carrying tens of millions in debt.

What should have been a bright future was now completely ruined.

Ruined by that recording of Xu Qingzhu's.

Ruined by their step-by-step strategic PR campaign.

If back then she had been shallow, not understanding why she lost so badly, not understanding how things had come to that point.

Then looking back on it now, what was there not to understand?

It was clearly to lure her out from behind the scenes, to make her face public condemnation—that's why they had laid trap after trap.

Until she thought she had enough certainty to win.

Yet she never expected to fail at the last hurdle, losing in utter disgrace.

She blamed Bai Weiwei for being stupid without knowing it, blamed Bai Weiwei for being too jealous.

She also blamed herself for not being able to keep her composure.

Chen Liuying loved beautiful things. The first time she saw Xu Qingzhu, she thought this person was beautiful.

So beautiful it made you want to take a taste.

These days she had also been constantly trying to make a comeback, but every attempt ended in miserable failure.

Besides infamy, she got nothing.

But why?

She had worked so hard to get to that point—what did those young misses who were born with everything understand?

They understood nothing.

Chen Liuying's clothes were out of season, long pants and long sleeves, looking exceptionally plain.

She didn't look like a female celebrity at all.

Those glamorous days were gone. She could no longer stand under the spotlight, admired by thousands.

Her life was wretched, unbearable, covered in mud.

Yet those people were clean and pristine, their lives going smoothly, living in the sunshine, living in love.

It looked so beautiful.

What was there to envy?

A shadow flickered through Chen Liuying's eyes.

She thought: If I can't have it, I might as well destroy it.

Isn't the meaning of beautiful things' existence to be destroyed?

More beautiful than existing beauty is beauty that has been burned to ashes.

Chapter 120-6

//

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu hurriedly ate their meal.

After eating, Liang Shi drove back to the set while Xu Qingzhu stood downstairs watching her leave.

Outside, employees kept passing by. Those who recognized Xu Qingzhu greeted her, and she responded to all of them with a cold face and a nod.

Liang Shi rolled down the car window and said to her gently: "I'm leaving then."

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

Liang Shi's gaze at her was somewhat lingering and tender, but the car window slowly rose.

Liang Shi sighed silently, feeling stifled somehow.

They would clearly see each other again, yet she still felt reluctant to part.

Just as the car window was slowly closing, the passenger side door was suddenly opened, and the sound of it closing caught Liang Shi off guard, startling her.

She saw that Xu Qingzhu—who had just been serious and proper in front of the employees—was now staring at her profile.

Those beautiful eyes gazed straight at her. She didn't know if it was her imagination, but she actually saw a glimmer of tears.

Liang Shi asked gently: "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu licked her lips, then leaned her body forward and kissed her directly.

Liang Shi: "..."

It wasn't a lingering kiss.

Liang Shi's hand had originally been hanging at her side. A moment later, it landed on her back. Their bodies were separated by flowers, separated by the center console, yet they closed their eyes, lips touching lips, their breaths intertwining in the cramped space.

A moment later, both stopped at the same time, foreheads pressed together.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers hooked around the ends of Liang Shi's hair. Her cool voice was tinged with a hint of desire, sounding ambiguous and alluring.

Liang Shi couldn't help herself and pressed another kiss to her glistening lips.

Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes fluttered up and down like crow feathers. She said in a muffled voice: "Teacher Liang~"

Liang Shi's fingertips landed on the curve of her ear, gently caressing.

The warm breath from Xu Qingzhu's words fell on her nose. The pleasant scent of strawberry Baileys dispersed inside the car, making one feel slightly intoxicated.

Liang Shi responded: "Mm?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed against her lips, her voice softening: "Remember to miss me."

Chapter 120-7

//

She would.

As Liang Shi drove away from the Minghui Jewelry building, she was still thinking: How could she not miss her?

This was truly a wondrous feeling.

In her past twenty-five years, this was the first time she had felt this way.

Her heart beat in rhythm with another person.

When thinking of her, a smile would naturally appear.

After returning to the set, the days went on as usual.

Liang Shi was someone with fairly strong adaptability. She had originally thought that after not joining a production for so long, she wouldn't be able to adapt to the fast pace of the crew. But after arriving, she found she adapted quite well.

When facing the camera, she would naturally cast aside all distracting thoughts. She was the character herself, going through take after take, reciting lines again and again.

Through filming, she truly walked into another person's world.

Even if it was just a fictional person.

Though sometimes while filming, she would wonder: Did this character, in the parts not filmed, also exist as a flesh-and-blood person?

Did they also have other stories unknown to others?

But these were just her own idle thoughts.

However, things on set weren't quite so peaceful. After the trending search incident that day, the crew started encountering some strange events.

Especially the other female lead in the drama, Shu Yi.

First, she was screaming in the hallway in the middle of the night, saying she had seen a ghost.

Then she went to knock on Zhao Ying's door in the middle of the night, scaring Zhao Ying half to death and putting Zhao Ying in a poor state.

But by the next day, Shu Yi would ask in surprise: "I did that?"

Having forgotten everything completely.

At first, it was only her experiencing this. After it happened several times, the director obliquely asked Shu Yi's manager if she had any mental health conditions.

Shu Yi's manager vaguely revealed that since Shu Yi's mother passed away the year before last, she couldn't handle the blow and had developed a sleepwalking habit.

But she repeatedly assured that there were no other mental health issues.

Less than a day later, a stunt double in the crew rolled down from halfway up a mountain while hiking.

Then in less than half a day, a cameraman who usually looked very robust got diarrhea so badly he collapsed from dehydration and had to be sent to the hospital.

Things were getting increasingly bizarre. The director held a brief meeting that day, telling everyone to be more careful in their daily activities and to prevent such incidents from happening again.

A producer furrowed his brow and said eerily: "Did we provoke something?"

The words were veiled, but those who had worked on productions for years understood.

For instance, every opening ceremony wasn't just to announce that filming had begun—offerings had to be made.¹

Especially in the entertainment industry, quite a few people believed in these things.

There were even rumors that those big-name celebrities kept things at home, and some even brought them from abroad.²

Anyway, the rumors in the industry were a mix of truth and fiction.

Liang Shi only learned after coming here that it wasn't just her original world that was like this—this world was the same.

More than once, she had heard people gossiping in the bathroom about how so-and-so in the industry had kept something and suffered backlash.

At first, she didn't understand those veiled terms, but as the mysterious incidents increased over these past two days, more and more people were saying such things.

Once the producer opened this topic, someone suggested: "How about we invite a master to check the feng shui?"

Soon, all sorts of voices filled the meeting room.

"The key question is which master to invite? I feel like there's something wrong with this place."

"It's not just our crew—the crew filming in the back garden has problems every few days too."

"We're actually doing okay. Yesterday, someone in the back garden crew almost died, and they had to stop filming for a day."

"No wonder the rent for this villa was so cheap—turns out it's haunted."

"..."

Everyone discussed animatedly. At first, they kept their voices low, but later they just started discussing loudly.

Zhao Ying had stayed up two nights in a row after being scared by Shu Yi. With two huge dark circles under her eyes, she was starting to look like a national treasure.³

She sat there listlessly, while Shu Yi—the main subject of these incidents—actually seemed fine.

Liang Shi didn't feel anything either. She was the same as usual.

Even on the night when Shu Yi was screaming in the hallway saying she saw a ghost, Liang Shi had slept through till morning with her earplugs in.

Mainly because she had been video-calling with Xu Qingzhu that night. Xu Qingzhu had received something urgent to handle, and Liang Shi had kept her company. By the time she went to sleep, it was almost one o'clock.

Shu Yi's screaming happened right when she was in deep sleep.

Only now, hearing everyone's discussion getting more and more heated, did she start to feel a bit creeped out.

-
1. Opening ceremony offerings (开机仪式): In the Chinese entertainment industry, it's traditional to hold a ceremony before filming begins, which includes burning incense and making offerings to deities or spirits to pray for a smooth production. This practice stems from folk religious beliefs. ↵
 2. Keeping things (养东西): A euphemism in Chinese folk belief referring to raising supernatural entities or spirits for personal gain, such as luck or success. The "backlash" mentioned refers to the belief that these entities can turn against their keepers. ↵
 3. National treasure (国宝): A humorous reference to giant pandas, China's national treasure, which are known for their distinctive black circles around their eyes. ↵

Chapter 120-8

Zhao Ying no longer dared to sit next to Shu Yi. She was now sitting between Liang Shi and Yan Xi. While listening to them discuss, she couldn't help but say: "If it doesn't work, just invite one. Or let's change filming locations—this is too scary."

Liang Shi handed her the throw pillow from her own chair, but Zhao Ying still had no energy.

After hearing this, the director became completely dazed. Finally, seeing their argument getting more and more heated, he couldn't help but slam the table and say: "Alright, let's take a day off first. Everyone go back and rest. I'll think it over."

What he meant by "think it over" was keeping the producer who had suggested inviting a master to check the feng shui behind, and the two of them went off to discuss.

After leaving the meeting room, Liang Shi asked Zhao Ying: "Ying-jie, are you okay? I have some calming incense. Want me to give you a few sticks?"

"Does it work?" Zhao Ying asked. "Give me some then."

Liang Shi said: "It works pretty well for me. You can try it."

Zhao Ying yawned, her whole being sunk in a low mood. "I'll come get it from you later then. My god, I don't care which deity it is—as long as they can resolve this for me, that's fine. I really can't take it anymore."

She complained all the way back to her trailer.

After Zhao Ying left, Yan Xi sidled up to her and said: "You two are close?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"It's alright." Liang Shi remembered Zhao Ying's previous advice and stayed neutral: "We're all in the same crew. Aren't you familiar with her?"

Yan Xi: "...Lifelong enemy."

Liang Shi smiled helplessly. Seeing that Yan Xi's condition wasn't great either, she asked: "Do you need some calming incense?"

"No need." Yan Xi also yawned. "I'm just tired from staying up to do homework. I really want to sleep."

Liang Shi: "..."

The matter was put on hold for a day.

The next day when work resumed, everyone had rested for a day and their spirits were much better.

But all sorts of rumors kept increasing, and the entire crew was on edge.

Some staff members who had originally been quite interested in this villa—poking around here and there when they first arrived—now didn't even dare to go inside the villa to use the bathroom.

Some people said just looking at that forest in the distance gave them the creeps.

Everyone was thoroughly frightened.

They filmed half of the morning's scenes. Everyone's condition was poor, and the coordination was only passable at best. The entire crew's progress slowed down.

Liang Shi's scenes were all being filmed together, much faster than she had imagined.

She had originally thought it would take at least half a month, but now it looked like ten days. However, because of this whole situation, progress was delayed again.

During a break, the director received a phone call, covering the receiver and speaking very quietly.

After finishing the call, he hurriedly ran out.

Liang Shi sat to the side resting with Yan Xi, who had just finished her scene. Yan Xi had her eyes closed to rest them while going over lines for the next scene with Liang Shi.

Having a partner like this made filming very comfortable for Liang Shi.

As long as the crew returned to normal working pace, she would definitely be able to wrap up within ten days.

After a while, the two were still earnestly rehearsing when the previously lifeless crew suddenly erupted with excitement. She heard quite a few gasps.

Yan Xi curiously turned to look first, then tugged at Liang Shi after seeing. "They actually came."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi happened to have her back to the sunlight. When she turned around now, the sun was glaring. She raised her hand to shield her eyes, and then saw a figure wearing Taoist robes.

The person had white hair and a white beard, but their face was quite young. Because they were very thin, the Taoist robes looked loose and baggy on them, but they truly did have an air of immortal elegance about them.

Yan Xi complained from the side: "Won't people say we're promoting superstition?"

But Liang Shi didn't register Yan Xi's words.

She stared at that figure and suddenly curved her lips into an amused smile.

Saying he wasn't in Haizhou City—he was just avoiding her, that's all.

This person was none other than Daoist Master Yunyin, whom Liang Shi had gone up Cloud Peak Mountain three times without seeing. She never expected to run into him here.

Liang Shi didn't expose herself. While he wasn't looking her way, she turned around and lowered her head to continue looking at the script, though her mind was already racing with a thousand thoughts.

Yan Xi, however, had no mind for rehearsing anymore. She said in a low voice: "I think Shu Yi just has schizophrenia. And those people having accidents—there are nearly a hundred people in the crew. Isn't it normal for some accidents to happen? Does it have to be supernatural? Why are people in the entertainment industry all so superstitious? I don't understand."

"Better safe than sorry, I guess." Liang Shi said. "Besides, things have escalated to this point. It's also to reassure everyone."

Yan Xi frowned: "I'm in the middle of applying for the Three Goods Student award.¹ If I get photographed with this kind of thing, can I still get it?"

Liang Shi: "..."

This delicate princess didn't live like a young miss at all.

More like a study grind.²

Liang Shi answered patiently: "It won't affect it."

Yan Xi: "You're not from our school. How would you know?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Yan Xi had just said that subconsciously. When she first found out that Liang Shi graduated from Guangliu University—that diploma mill—her first words had been: "How did my senior fall for you?"

Liang Shi: "...Maybe it's personal charm."

But Yan Xi had only dissed her about her education that one time.

Afterward, she tried to avoid this topic as much as possible.

This young miss was delicate, but not annoying.

After she finished speaking just now, Liang Shi didn't think much of it, but Yan Xi's own thoughts went astray. She couldn't help but say: "Sorry, I wasn't trying to diss you."

Liang Shi smiled: "Then should I ask your senior for you?"

Yan Xi: "...My senior couldn't possibly know, because Senior Xu was on a full scholarship. And besides... a fairy couldn't possibly believe in feudal superstition!"

She said this with particular certainty.

-
1. Three Goods Student (三好学生): A prestigious student award in China given to students who excel in three areas: moral character, academics, and physical fitness. It's an important honor that can affect future academic and career opportunities. ↵
 2. Study grind (卷王): Chinese internet slang for someone who is extremely competitive academically, constantly studying and striving to outperform others. The term comes from "内卷" (involution), referring to intense competition. ↵

Chapter 120-9

At the mention of Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi also chuckled lightly. "Probably."

Her tone was a bit perfunctory. Right now, all she could think about was Daoist Master Yunyin and Qiu Zimin.

She had seen Daoist Master Yunyin's face in the original owner's memories.

That person had been sitting in a dimly lit wooden cabin, the room filled with the fragrance of tea. Facing the young girl with shadowed eyes, the Daoist master had said: "Liang Shi, your hostile energy is too heavy."

The young girl lazily didn't look at him, her gaze disdainful.

Later, after the coffin room had been set up, the original owner had also gone up Cloud Peak Mountain, but never saw this person again.

After that, the original owner adapted to that room, adapted to all of Qiu Zimin's behaviors. To her, being obedient was enough—she didn't need to have any other thoughts.

The director led Daoist Master Yunyin into the villa, and the crew started buzzing with discussion.

Liang Shi sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: [I saw that old Taoist geezer.]

Xu Qingzhu: [...Who?]

Liang Shi: [Yunyin.]

Xu Qingzhu replied after a few seconds: [Remember to record.]

Liang Shi: [Okay.]

The director was very respectful toward this so-called master throughout. They walked around the villa for about ten or so minutes.

After the villa, there was still the back garden. Round after round, it took about an hour.

This hour felt especially long to Liang Shi.

She kept her eyes fixed on Yunyin, afraid this person would run off the next second.

The character she was playing had a folding knife—the kind without a sharpened blade. As the director's conversation with Yunyin was nearing its end, she slipped the folding knife into her pocket, asked Yan Xi for a hair tie, and casually twisted her hair up into a loose bun.

Yan Xi beside her watched her expression turn serious and couldn't help but ask: "What are you going to do? Fight?"

Liang Shi stood up and tugged at the hem of her white shirt, the corner of her lips curving up. "Yeah."

After saying that, she didn't bother with Yan Xi's expression and turned to leave.

Leaving Yan Xi standing there dumbfounded.

This person could fight?

But Liang Shi didn't care. She walked to a secluded area on the outskirts—also the route Yunyin's vehicle would have to pass through—drove her car over to that area, and then sat in the car waiting.

The director and Yunyin had a very pleasant conversation. Feeling like he had received guidance from a master, he stuffed a big red envelope into Yunyin's hands when seeing him off, thanking him for coming.

After Yunyin accepted it, he got in the car and left.

Sitting in the car, he opened the red envelope and counted—thirty thousand yuan.

Quite a decent haul.

Just as he was about to stuff the money back into the red envelope, the car braked sharply. He wasn't seated stably and his whole body lurched forward, scattering money all over the car.

Yunyin was furious and berated the driver: "How are you driving?"

The driver was still shaken, stammering: "Someone drifted over and completely blocked our path."

Yunyin: "..."

He raised his head to look out the window and spotted a familiar figure standing outside.

Liang Shi bent her finger and rapped on the glass, then directly pulled open the door from outside, meeting Yunyin's somewhat frightened gaze.

Liang Shi said coldly: "Get out of the car."